



How to Write the
PERFECT
PERSONAL
ESSAY **2023**

US University Admissions



A CRIMSON EDUCATION PUBLICATION

Table of Contents

1. What is the Personal Essay?

2. How a Strong Personal Essay Will Boost Your Chances of Admission

3. Writing the Personal Essay: Key Steps Simplified

4. Tips From a Former Admissions Officer

5. Perfect Personal Essays

• Ana — New York University	<u>10</u>
• Andrea — Yale University, Duke University, Northwestern University	<u>12</u>
• Anonymous — Columbia University	<u>13</u>
• Anonymous — University of Chicago	<u>15</u>
• Fara — Stanford University, Yale University, New York University, and more	<u>17</u>
• Felipe — Columbia University, University of Southern California, Boston University	<u>19</u>
• Guilherme — University of Pennsylvania, Yale University, Columbia University, Brown University, and more	<u>21</u>
• Hoyoel — UCLA, UC Berkeley, UC San Diego, UC Davis, University of Southern California	<u>23</u>
• Juliano — Dartmouth College, University of Pennsylvania, Yale University	<u>26</u>
• Julien — Boston University, Cornell University, Dartmouth College, Yale University, University of Pennsylvania, Swarthmore, Vassar College, The College of William & Mary	<u>28</u>
• Kavi — UCLA, Queen's University	<u>30</u>
• Maddie — UC Berkeley, Northwestern University, and more	<u>32</u>
• Marcus — New York University, University of Hawai'i	<u>34</u>
• Mehdi — UC Berkeley, Johns Hopkins University, University of Pennsylvania, Yale University	<u>36</u>
• Raghuram — Johns Hopkins University	<u>38</u>
• Saanvi — Johns Hopkins University	<u>40</u>
• Sarah — University of Chicago, New York University, Duke University	<u>42</u>
• Takenoshin — Harvard University, Yale University, Columbia University	<u>44</u>
• Yuri — Duke University, Northwestern University	<u>46</u>
• Zuzanna — Harvard University	<u>48</u>

What is the Personal Essay?

The Common App Personal Essay is 650-word essay that is sent to every university you apply to through the portal. It offers admissions officers an opportunity to gain a deeper understanding of who you are — both as a student and as a person.

Your Personal Essay should:

1. Contextualize your grades and extracurriculars
2. Differentiate you from your peers
3. Reflect on significant moments that helped you grow
4. Show admissions officers why you are a great candidate for their institution.

In the Common App, you can choose from 7 prompts, each inviting you to explore different aspects of your life, including:

- Your background, identity, interests, talents
- A challenge, setback, or failure and what you learned
- A time you've questioned or challenged a belief and your thinking / the outcome
- A problem you've solved or would like to solve and why
- An accomplishment, event, or realization that sparked personal growth
- A concept/idea that makes you lose track of time and why
- Any topic of your choice

When you apply for university in the United States, there are a few application portals you can go through. While the most popular is the Common Application, there are others such as the Coalition Application, the Universal College Application, and the University of California (UC) Application. Some colleges will even have their own individual portal!



If you are applying to a school within the **University of California** system, your essay will be slightly different. Also known as the "Personal Insights," students must answer 4 of 8 questions. Each answer has a maximum of 350 words, and the applicant can choose whichever question they would like to answer.

The questions are as follows:

1. Describe an example of your leadership experience in which you have positively influenced others, helped resolve disputes or contributed to group efforts over time.
2. Every person has a creative side, and it can be expressed in many ways: problem solving, original and innovative thinking, and artistically, to name a few. Describe how you express your creative side.
3. What would you say is your greatest talent or skill? How have you developed and demonstrated that talent over time?
4. Describe how you have taken advantage of a significant educational opportunity or worked to overcome an educational barrier you have faced.
5. Describe the most significant challenge you have faced and the steps you have taken to overcome this challenge. How has this challenge affected your academic achievement?
6. Think about an academic subject that inspires you. Describe how you have furthered this interest inside and/or outside of the classroom.
7. What have you done to make your school or your community a better place?
8. Beyond what has already been shared in your application, what do you believe makes you a strong candidate for admissions to the University of California?

To craft a compelling application, your Personal Essay and Personal Insights must bring together a common theme in your academics, extracurriculars, and community involvement. Think of it as the central storyline woven throughout your college application, connecting your academics and extracurriculars and demonstrating the 'why' behind the courses and activities you've participated in throughout high school.



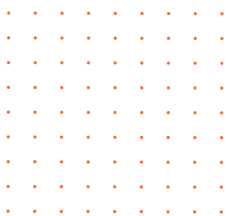
How a Strong Personal Essay Will Boost Your Chances of Admission

A strong personal essay will illustrate your personal qualities and priorities, giving admissions officers a glimpse into the kind of student you would be on their campus.

Examples of personal qualities that admissions officers look for include:

- **Self-awareness and reflection**
- **Social awareness**
- **Willingness to grow**
- **Problem-solving skills**
- **Critical thinking**
- **Service-oriented mindset**
- **Compassionate nature**
- **Resourcefulness**

With thousands of applications from outstanding students from all around the world, it is important that your essay helps you stand out from the crowd. By telling your unique story in a powerful way, admissions officers are more likely to remember who you are, thus boosting your chances of admission.



Writing the Personal Essay: Key Steps Simplified

While there are many ways to write a good essay, here is a roadmap on how to get started.

STEP 1

Brainstorm impactful experiences and passions.

Review your prompts. Then, using paper, an app, or your phone, write down as much as you can, responding directly to those prompts. Once you're done, filter through your results and rank the results according to which experiences and passions have impacted your growth the most. No major transformation is necessary; after all, many of you are still in high school. That being said, there still needs to be some kind of growth demonstrated.

Most good essays begin at a specific point in time and revolve around a specific event. Your passions can also work as a starting point for an essay topic, so long as you're clear on how the passion has impacted you and your view of the world.

STEP 2

Figure out what you learned.

Once you've decided on your topic, list out:

- + What you learned
- + Why it matters to you
- + How it connects to who you are now
- + How it will help you become who you want to be
- + How this has helped your perspectives grow and change over time

Admissions officers care more about the insights you have than they do about the event that you're writing about in your essay. You don't need to tell a sad or traumatic story — and in fact, trying to lean on sympathy doesn't work with admissions officers. They want to see **personal growth**, even if it comes from seemingly insignificant experiences.

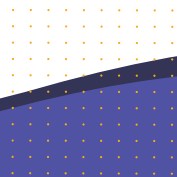
STEP 3

Draft a very rough 1st copy.

Assemble your notes and puzzle them together. Don't focus on perfection or the word count yet. Make sure that your writing involves:

- Your experience
- Making sure your 'story' develops with a beginning, middle, and end
- A clear resolution or lesson
- How you will apply this lesson in the future

Having trouble writing or getting started? Try voice recording your thoughts, asking a friend to scribe, or using voice-to-text!



STEP 4

Edit.

Now that your first draft is complete, you'll want to edit for grammar, word choice, and clarity. Work to ensure that your essay is focused on your reflections. Once you're done, feel free to ask trusted friends and family to review and provide suggested edits to your work. Feel free to accept or reject their suggestions. This will lead you to create 2nd, 3rd, and 4th drafts of your Personal Essay.

STEP 5

Double-check your deadlines.

Are you looking to apply Early Action/Early Decision? Or just in the regular round? Nevertheless, you'll need to make sure you know when your applications are due! Most Early Action deadlines are around November 1st, but some might even be as early as October 15th! Otherwise, regular round applications are usually due around the end of December to early January.

STEP 6

Finalize your essay.

Some people need to make 5 drafts. Others 10. Some, 3. Whatever that number is for you, that's okay so long as you're not falling into the trap of "analysis paralysis."

Focus on insights and takeaways from an experience, rather than the experience itself.



Successful essays are often humble and reflect a student's capacity to struggle with, and conquer difficulty, rather than implying that the student is already an expert. Students should not be afraid to admit their mistakes, show how mentors inspired them, and celebrate their resilience in times of hardship!

Tips From a Former Admissions Officer

Meet Eileen Dougherty. Eileen was a Former Admissions Officer at three US universities and, most recently, at the University of Pennsylvania. As an admissions officer for nearly 10 years, she visited high schools around the country to inform prospective students about the school, evaluated applications, and interviewed potential candidates. Eileen has been an admissions consultant for the past 5 years, and her students have been accepted to many of the best schools in the US. Here are some of her top tips on both what to include and what NOT to include.



What to Write

- Content that is unique to you
- Content that allows you to explore your personal traits and characteristics (ingenuity, resourcefulness, resilience, creativity, etc.)
- Content that shows your personality (sense of humor, intellectual curiosity, etc.)
- Show, don't tell!



What NOT to Write

- A list of achievements and accomplishments
- Content that rehashes what is already listed in other sections of your Common App
- Unnecessarily ornate and/or convoluted language
- Content that tries to prove your academic superiority (like the time you won a competition or prestigious award)

Need help crafting, refining, or polishing your essay?

Our essay mentors are graduates from the very universities you are applying to, so they know what it takes to tell your story and communicate to admissions officers why you'd be a great addition to their diverse student body!

[BOOK A FREE CONSULTATION](#)

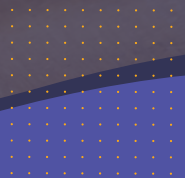
Now that you understand what makes a Personal Essay stand out, it's time to see a few examples! The following essays were carefully crafted by students who collaborated with their Crimson essay mentors to effectively showcase their passions, perspectives, and personalities on paper. These final essays helped our students gain admission to the most competitive universities in the US. We hope you find them helpful and inspiring!





Perfect Personal Essays

(Common App)



In a matter of seconds, I went from lying in my bed watching TikToks to sobbing from frustration, confusion, and hurt. When my mom received the phone call from her sister that lives in Colombia, she came running downstairs screaming, “mi Abuela!” We knew from the call that my Abuela was unwell, but with the distance separating my mom and me from my family, we could only hope for the best.

My mom had me at sixteen, and since she was my only parent, all her Colombian family felt like my immediate family. We left this family when I was seven, looking for better education and a chance for prosperity. Because of the distance between my family in Colombia and my mom and I, we always had a practical backup plan in case something happened to my mom. Still, I didn’t have a plan for how to face the death of a loved one from afar emotionally. Because of my mom’s youth, my great-grandmother always felt like a grandma, and I thought I would have more time with her.

When Abuela passed away, I hadn’t seen my extended family in a year. Though my mom had kept asking me to go on a short getaway to Colombia, I said no because I was scared of missing school. I was frustrated with myself, my selfish excuses, and the distance. We couldn’t just get in a car and go to her house. I had to sit on the 6-hour plane ride wishing for it to be a prank, waiting for my mom to pinch me and wake me up from the nightmare. The news of her death wasn’t sinking in.

Challenging times like these are when I start questioning our life choices: should we even live in the US? When we left, it was worth it to escape the toxic elements of my dad’s family, but now that I’m mature enough to create boundaries, is it worth staying here? In Colombia, my mom wouldn’t have to worry much about me because we would always be surrounded and supported by family. But, while my mom and I may get emotional security in Colombia, we wouldn’t have the financial security we have in the USA.

While I still haven’t accepted Abuelita’s passing, it has made death more of a reality, and I know she will always be alongside me and will keep our family together.

Being in Colombia after her passing was the first time we were all together as a family, putting our differences aside to grieve together, remember Abuelita, and make a delicious paella. My great-grandmother always saw me as a little girl; I was her Ana Matilde, her first and only great-grandchild, who will put her dreams and her family before anything else, just like Abuelita taught her. I regret that she won’t see me graduate from high school, but she will always be with me. Whenever I eat chicken, rice, and corn, I’m back at the kitchen table playing cards with her as we share our favorite dish. I will share it with my friends and family as they get to know the Ana that Abuelita didn’t get to know. As I continue growing, whatever version of myself I am will always contain a little bit of Abuelita.

Since Abuelita died in June of this year, I have thought of death with less fear and more adaptation. Abuela's passing was deeply challenging, but it brought my faraway family together. I have also learned to appreciate the time I spend with my mom while it's just us two before I leave for college next year, knowing everything is going to be okay and alleviating the guilt of leaving home. Accepting death goes hand in hand with taking responsibility for life; now that I consciously value my time with my loved ones, death has begun to feel like another part of life.





In a discreet wooden box lay my memories as Polaroids captured by my dad. Unlike most, our eyes don't serve as the ultimate testament to our experiences because my dad and I suffer from congenital nystagmus, a condition of involuntary and uncontrollable eye movement that distorts vision. We therefore rely on his Polaroid Sun 600 to capture and stabilize our memories. In other words, Polaroid pictures symbolize long-term memories stored for later access. Today, these tangible recollections preserve my authenticity and reveal snapshots of my personal development.

The back of Photograph 1 reads: "Andrea gets her first pair of glasses (08/13/2007)." I sit in the ophthalmologist's office, subtly announcing my resignation by gazing at the floor. A month before, I had begun using an odd pair of rectangular magenta glasses that drew attention to my eyes, making my involuntary and repetitive eye movements more noticeable. Afraid of being questioned about my condition, I avoided eye contact and failed to ask for accommodations at school. Unwittingly, I became an introvert, yet to discover the value of adaptability.

Photograph 2 is labeled: "Dad runs the New York marathon (11/03/2013)." I stand beside my dad, who seems elated while he holds his medal with both hands. I can recall how he strenuously thrust forward as he was approaching the finish line. This was the first time that I saw movement as a positive force. As an 11-year-old, I started to embrace my condition by comparing my dad's graceful movements while running to the movement of my eyes. As a result, I began sitting in the front of every class, requesting adapted materials, and candidly telling my classmates about my condition. By the time I was 13, I had consecutively been chosen as a class representative and had a variety of friend groups. Nystagmus no longer defined me because I began to develop an adaptive mindset that empowered me to openly face uncertainty.

The caption of Photograph 3 reads: "Mexico Earthquake (9/21/2017)." I am loading emergency food and water supplies into a cargo van for disaster-affected families. Two days earlier, a 7.1 magnitude earthquake hit Mexico, opening my eyes to our broken health system and deficient policy response. However, the earthquake also allowed me to witness Mexico's adaptive reaction to severe adversity and encouraged me to found Yodoc, a nonprofit organization. Through Yodoc, I seek to empower Mexican youth and prepare them to drive social change by exposing them to STEM and healthcare. Having embraced my nystagmus and seen the potential of an adaptive mindset, I believe that Mexican youth need to be resourceful and emotionally intuitive in order to face our country's uncertain future.

Nystagmus has fueled my process of self-discovery by forcing me to adapt to my environment. My growing self-assurance is evident: I used to avoid eye contact, but I now treasure the opportunity to interact with others and thrive in a myriad of social settings. Uncertainty is now a sign of confidence because I have embraced all aspects of my identity. I owe the existence of this archive of personal development to my dad and his Polaroid Sun 600. However, in college, I will begin to capture my memories through my own lens. I am eager to see where I will take the first Polaroid and where that memory will take me.

Disciplined was the first word I used to describe myself. I can picture myself in the mirror: hairspray in one hand, hairbrush in the other, slicking back my hair so not a single hair would budge as I danced—the lengths I would go to to look like an egg. Just like ballet required that level of tight control, I was like that as a person, too.

I was raised in an environment where emotions were looked down upon. My mother always told me not to cry, even when it was warranted. As a dancer, I was trained to constantly ignore pain to make physical challenges look effortless, my face hiding everything. I did the same for my thoughts and feelings, so that the inside of my head wouldn't budge either.

In high school, I began seeing contradictions to what I already knew, such as when my American textbook called Atatürk, someone more than a hero to me, a dictator. I was confused by the way things were "incorrectly" portrayed, but after investigating my thoughts, I realized that there isn't a singular point of view that's absolutely right, emboldening me to share more of my own personal beliefs.

When my ideas started changing, so did my feelings. I grew confident, challenging ideas and defending my own. Being more curious and open changed me as an artist. In my recent dance project, I portrayed *Fear and Desire* wearing a motion-capture suit, my dancing completely digitized and my face invisible. Emotions were the centerpiece of the project. Through this new dance performance, I had to let go of personal control and fear holding me back: my muscles relaxed and my face softened. After 14 years of dancing, I was finally free. Similarly with piano, I started feeling my pieces that I played rather than just listening to them. By exposing my vulnerability, I positively changed the energy of the room; I know the audience could feel my expression, too. Deepening and personalizing myself as an artist led to the most surprising development: it brought into focus my relationship with people, not only music and movement. After first expressing myself to an audience, I began showing my truth to my friends, gaining the courage to open up one-on-one. Performing was like a rehearsal for more genuine connections in real life.

In my relationships, I've become candid and expressive, which has led to solving conflicts without hurting the other person due to bottled up emotions spilling out. Being open is not necessarily encouraged in Turkish society—I had experienced negative responses to my vulnerability, which made me fear it. I used to expect people to understand what I felt from the way I sulked or didn't talk after a small conflict because I was afraid to speak out. However, once I opened up to my friends, I was met with comfort and acceptance. I also noticed that not everyone responded the same way. When I told my mother how her words sometimes hurt me, she grew defensive and didn't listen to me. I would have done the same. But upon being more open, instead of blaming her, I tried to explain to her my own experience and point of view, and she responded by doing the same. We were both viewing the situation from completely different viewpoints, not accounting for what the other was feeling. Though it is not completely smooth, we both are working on it, and it all comes from our vulnerability.

I used to believe that being emotional made me appear weak. Now I know emotions aren't weak—they're human. I see my emotional vulnerability as a strength. And *disciplined* turned from emotional control into passion. After all, flexibility, not rigidity, is what makes a good dancer, pianist, thinker, friend...and daughter.



Cheese Dumplings

Whenever I eat ravioli, pierogi, or any other dumplings, I'm amazed by the variety of tastes wrapped inside that thin layer of dough. In my culture, dumplings — or *jiaozi* — aren't merely about flavor. They are the core of Chinese tradition, and the absolute star of the Spring Festival feast.

In my junior year, my 82-year-old grandma flew to America to celebrate the Spring Festival with us. I begged my mom for the last few medallions of dough and made my own filling: pork, cabbage, mushrooms, and one more secret ingredient.

Against my mother's protest, I added American cheese in the dumpling filling.

What went in the dumplings was more than just cheese. It was three years of replacing chopsticks with forks, replacing *qipaos* with skinny jeans and sandals, replacing timid smiles with hugs and screams when greeting mere acquaintances. After coming to the U.S., I abandoned my old preferences and tried to negate my past fourteen years in China. My alteration, however, alienated me from my family: while my parents listened to Chinese classics in the car, I put on headphones and listened to Taylor Swift; while they flipped through Chinese TV dramas in one room, I watched *Game of Thrones* in another. Once, when someone complimented me on my language ability, my parents thanked them with heavy accents and sighed: "See? Only young people can assimilate into a new culture. We're too old for that." I, too, thought a stark line separated us. Our paths diverged; I was on the road toward Americanization, while my parents stubbornly persisted in their native culture.

However, I didn't want my beloved *jiaozi* to follow my parents' path. These dumplings deserved the same transformation that I went through, and the cheese filling was a perfect example.

On the night of the feast, dumpling soup was served. My cheese dumplings did not go unnoticed: my father's face twisted, my mom put down her spoon.

Then it was Grandma's turn.

"Aiyoo, why is this dumpling stinky? My dear, was this filling unrefrigerated for too long?"

Afterwards, everybody burst into laughter while I sat there with a weak smile. My mom sprung to the kitchen to boil more "normal" dumplings. But my grandma stopped her: "No, no! It's Joy's* new invention. Maybe I'll learn to like it if I eat more!" She bit into another one. "Mmm, not bad!"

I was speechless. How could an 82-year-old woman molded by conservative Chinese society be so receptive to my "Americanized" *jiaozi*?

Did she accept them out of love? No—my parents loved me no less. Perhaps it was her age and life experiences that rendered her tolerant of any novelty.

I wondered: perhaps the Great Wall separating me from my elders was not impassible. After my grandma proved that age didn't prevent assimilation and a generation gap wasn't inevitable, I tried harder to bridge this gap within my family, and I noticed that, as a result, my parents reciprocated. They encouraged me to volunteer at the town hall for the presidential election although they were apolitical. My father watched the Super Bowl and happily bought a Boston Red Sox T-shirt. My mother learned to roast turkey for Thanksgiving and asked me to walk her through their tax returns.

To first-generation immigrants like myself, cultural exchange is like cooking: you don't have to abandon one ingredient for another; instead, every chef can blend any ingredients in different ratios to create distinct flavors. My flavor had more cheese than my parents', but both are delicious in their own way. I no longer hide the Chinese part of me, or perceive my Americanization as a trade-off for sacrificing family relationships. Instead, I am proud of being at the intersection of two distinct cultures. Now, with my family reminding me of my roots, I am more confident to explore other cultures, and to add new ingredients to my jiaozi.





“Èkó ò ní bàjé ooooo,” my Grandma said to us in Yoruba at our annual Christmas dinner in Lagos, a bustling city in Nigeria.

I sat there confused about what this phrase meant but continued to speak in my English accent and show off the new vocabulary I had learnt from boarding school in England. As the granddaughter of the event, I thought it would only be polite to introduce myself around.

“Good evening, my name is Faramola Bakare and I am going to be the President of Nigeria,” I proclaimed loudly in my age-eleven voice. An elderly woman said to me, “that’s not how to pronounce your name, young lady, you’re speaking like Western people.” Everyone laughed, but I did not get the joke.

At school in England, I was known as the ‘cool’ Nigerian: the Nigerian who travels the world, attends the hottest concerts and hosts exuberant “owambes” (grandiose parties). I liked this version of me: it was the popular me. When I showed my friends pictures of Lagos, I only showed them the fancy shops and the sandy dunes of its beaches. I deleted the pictures of bad days in Lagos and maintained a perfect image of Lagos in order to counter the narrative of Africa, ‘the heart of darkness’ riddled with poverty. The illusion I had painted of Lagos to my schoolmates was too beautiful to be tainted by the bleaker reality: rubbish lining the streets, children begging on the side of the road, blaring melodies of police officers with AK-47s and nowhere to go. In truth, I was ashamed of Lagos.

Age 16, I was driving back from our family-organised food drive in Elegbata, an impoverished neighbourhood on the outskirts of Lagos, when my mum and I realised that we had a few more relief packages left. We decided to stop and distribute the rest of the packages in the community. In the blink of an eye, an army of men rushed to the car like they were chasing their kidnapped children. Soon after, violence broke out. I could feel the hunger and desperation of the people, a moshpit of anger. The turmoil reflected the disease caused by socio-economic disparity within the community. At that moment, I feared that there was no cure.

I recognized that I was hiding the reality of Lagos from my friends because it was the easier option. I couldn’t say my name because I didn’t know who I was. I realised that I could not help a country I did not identify with, that was the joke.

“Èkó ò ní bàjé” means “Lagos will not spoil”. I am learning to take pride in my country and acknowledge that to help Lagos not spoil, I have to play my part. I now understand that having the privilege of soaking up the sun on the sandy dunes cannot insulate me from Nigeria’s systematic issues.

More than ever, I am determined to understand Lagos’ complex nature and champion my Grandma’s mantra that Lagos will not spoil. To begin to address Lagos’s systematic issues, I lead an outreach supporting single mothers to launch

businesses in the Dopemu community. Last year, I created STEM in Africa (SIA), an organisation that raises awareness around careers in STEM for young African students. I believe advocating for STEM in Nigeria will catalyse a new way of thinking for the next generation of Africans. SIA has already impacted two hundred and thirty students' lives through STEM education and we are just getting started. I hope to better understand how to sustainably make an impact in communities.

At the inaugural ceremony of SIA, attended by the students and supporting partners, I stood to say, "Good evening, I am Faramola Bakare. Thank you for believing in the youth of Nigeria, you are leaving the nation in good hands. We have a long way to go, but Èkó ò ní bàjé ooooo."





The only sound my 13-year-old self could hear was that of powerful water droplets in the sink and the silver dishcloths rubbing the plates in that loathsome prison that was our kitchen.

The insufferable air in the atmosphere established that neither me nor Carolina, Melissa, and Isabella, my three little sisters, stood the mere presence of one another.

In truthfulness, though, I was only pretending to be an unapproachable and efficient dishwasher obligated to wash the same dishes repeatedly (instead of being able to experience his new video game or Lego set).

I was hiding the fact that my heart ached at the possibility of having ruined what I considered crucial relationships. But one thought wouldn't leave my mind as I drifted away from the endless dishes: the universe had extended its hand towards me with an opportunity for me to reconcile with them.

I needed them to know that I missed the times we played video games, build Legos, and watched Hell's Kitchen. Yes, that was it.

"You know, you're lucky I'm not Gordon Ramsey," I said, halting the monologue of the sink, "or else you'd all be gone by now."

They looked confused.

Yet I knew it was more than that. We had always loved the show.

"Are you going to help or just stand there?" Isabella retaliated.

I chose the first option.

I couldn't hide my eagerness as I explained how I had an idea to implement some changes in the kitchen based on my video games. By modifying some of our responsibilities there, we could escape from that place quicker.

My sisters' silence transformed my excitement into crestfallenness. I thought it was a matter of time before they would start yelling at me about how I repeatedly found a creative way to mess everything up.

Gradually, however, something else occurred.

Even though many of the visits my sisters paid me in my room had the purpose of me helping them with homework, I was now often relieved. It was as if they appeared to feel safer now when approaching me.

Maybe that is what our relationship lacked: an assurance that I cared.

These visits also propelled an unexpected feeling of excitement within me. I realized how rather simple things in my daily life, like a video game or a TV show, could play a role in something bigger than myself, such as a relationship.

I was motivated to replicate the idea of using my hobbies for a significant cause after seeing how it had a small but considerable impact on me and my sisters. Yet, I suppose I rooted my desire to be unapproachable (or shyness) so deep inside me that I had goosebumps at the thought of leaving my comfort zone for these experiences.

Still, I convinced myself to give it a chance, just like I did when I opted to count on my sisters for help in the kitchen.

This attempt, which started with me helping them with their homework, transformed itself into things like working on a scientific project which would help those who don't have access to clean water or collecting costumes for pediatric oncology patients undergoing harsh treatment.

Every time I made a minor difference by merely doing what I liked to do, I realized how I had been hiding so long behind a wall of unapproachability from countless opportunities before my stay in prison.

Now, when my sisters and I embark on our daily journeys to that place or on our occasional adventures to watch Hell's Kitchen, I often think of how something I dreaded allowed us to come together.

It showed me that if I could be more open-minded to even the smallest, meaningless experiences like dishwashing, I could be there for people the same way my sisters wished I were there for them.

And that also didn't mean I couldn't be an efficient and focused dishwasher when required.





I whizzed down the uneven road, wobbling on my yellow bicycle before careening over a ficus root. My grandfather was teaching me to ride a Brazilian Caloi, my first bike. On Fridays, he would pick me up at school and we would enjoy a lunch of fried eggs, red rice, and fresh jaboticaba—Brazilian cherries. After a siesta, we'd spend the rest of the day learning how to ride my Caloi at Ibirapuera Park.

My grandpa didn't believe in training wheels. I learned to ride by practicing among the holes and ancient tree roots in the asphalt. He would give me a strong shove, helping me find the bike's equilibrium point. Despite falling often and repeatedly applying burning iodine to my bruised knees, seeing my own progress—and my grandpa's pride—was what mattered most. Those shoves helped me grow comfortable with taking risks from a young age.

When I could finally stay up, my grandpa and I began to take longer rides in Ibirapuera. I raced him on the bike paths, as he shared stories of his childhood heroes, describing professional cyclists who passed through his village in Italy during the Giro d'Italia. As we passed Oscar Niemeyer's modernist buildings in the park, I asked my grandpa—himself a brilliant civil engineer—to teach me the physics that kept the edifices upright. He described how engineering, like learning how to ride a bike, requires continuously iterating: "If you stop trying and taking action, you'll lose balance and fall." These experiences piqued my curiosity about engineering and turned biking into a lifestyle.

During my cycling geek peak, I interned at a bike shop in my hometown. While selling bikes and accessories, I noticed how customers sought cycling as a means for sustainable living. Yet, ironically, the shop only sold metal bikes, which use non-renewable resources and end up in landfills. Provoked by the apparent contradiction that cycling's foundation wasn't truly sustainable, I asked the shop's owner why he only sold those bikes. "Of what else could they be built?", he replied. Perhaps this question was rhetorical, but I kept trying to come up with an answer.

Back in Ibirapuera Park, riding through a hundred-meter-long bamboo tunnel, I was fascinated by how the bamboo stalks waved with both strength and flexibility. I realized I could craft an equilibrium between the environment and material development. Those stalks represented the innovative path to manufacturing a vehicle that corresponded to cycling's call for sustainable living. I became determined to build a bike out of bamboo. After sketching bamboo frames in my notebook, I began prototyping and quickly learned that building a bamboo bike was easier said than done. In a few weeks, my attempted iterations had all spectacularly failed. The broken prototypes, however, reminded me of my grandpa's analogy between engineering and learning how to bike—if I persisted in creating new iterations, I would eventually succeed.

After studying how to treat bamboo with natural resin and fibers for durability, my plans started to mature. I built my first frame, handlebar, fork, and spokes. But how could I convince people to adopt such an unusual bicycle? The answer lied in

commercialization through entrepreneurship. I could only convince people to use a bamboo bike if I guaranteed that it solved a specific need. Commuters wanted to charge their electronics when going to work, so I crafted a phone-charging attachment after discussing the technology with engineers. What at first seemed like a unique, one-time prototype became a real-world product with a clear value proposition.

Reflecting back, those Friday afternoons with my grandpa taught me how to take initiative, persist, and use creativity to solve problems. I hope to apply my experiences by devising and commercializing innovative solutions to my country's urban mobility and energy issues. My grandfather's lessons have inspired me to help build a future in which humanity strikes a balance between technological advances and a sustainable relationship with the planet.





1. Please describe how you have prepared for your intended major, including your readiness to succeed in your upper-division courses once you enroll at the university.

My "click" moment came when I realized that beyond the impersonal and rigid nature of coded materials are the very subjective and well-intended goals of the programmer: every code was inputted for a specific, cognitive purpose.

To prepare for my major and career in connecting how programming can help improve neural functions, I have taken a streamlined approach to planning out a 2-year academic plan and maintaining a 4.0 GPA in all of my community college courses. I have also challenged myself to take math and cognitive science courses at UC Berkeley, where I realized the expectations of UC-level instruction and learned how to both discipline myself academically as well as to actively interact with my GSI's and professors through Office Hours in and out of the classroom. Specifically, I was encouraged to pursue my own research projects to apply what I learned to the real world; as a student researcher for RISE Research Group, my literary review of existing research in the field combined with my direct experimentation using Avogadro, a modeling program, I came to realize the importance of taking upper-division courses in cognitive science and programming and forming a fundamental understanding of a wider range of studies.

I want to use my UC education as a stepping stone to pursue a career in creating virtual realities by developing brain-computer interfaces in order to ultimately tackle the challenges of codifying the current-mysteries of the brain using concrete solutions, especially given the challenges of treating diseases invisible to the naked eye. As such, I plan to prepare myself by balancing my upper-division coursework with continuing to participate in research projects and other extracurricular activities. My goal is to balance what humans want through cognitive science courses, matched with the reality of how human brains act through psychology courses, with how humans interact with other humans or their surroundings based on these brain activities through anthropology and linguistic courses as well as field work, to ultimately use coding to create ideal models for these processes.

2. Describe an example of your leadership experience in which you have positively influenced others, helped resolve disputes, or contributed to group efforts over time.

Having experience as an international student myself, I have always been driven to wanting to help other international students in need. As such, I became a tutor and student counselor for UC Davis GUAP, a program designed to help international students balance their college courses with campus life.

Because GUAP was a fairly new program when I joined, my input went directly into the ears of the director. Specifically, when grades drop for domestic students this

may have been due to not studying enough or not understanding the materials; however, GUAP students from China or Korea who have been disciplined to study the course materials thoroughly, so I realized that the issue was more about how they did not understand the prompt or were not used to the formats and citation methods of the American college system. In other words, by assessing individual students' grades and academic performances, I was able to find patterns in grade drops to recognize the cultural differences that may prevent international students from excelling academically.

To solve this issue, I suggested providing tutoring sessions not just by subject, but also general info sessions to teach students how to organize their essay or lab report structures, and the materials and templates I made for my own students were eventually revised to become incorporated into the official GUAP curriculum as well. I also realized that GUAP had so many resources available to them that many students never even knew about, so I helped translate some of the most important PPT slides from the GUAP counselors and UC Davis websites into Korean and Chinese.

While my actions were driven by my desire to help out the individual students I was assigned to, by recognizing patterns in students' learning behaviors as well as knowing my team members well enough to accurately assess their needs is what allowed me to be able to find simple, direct solutions to help them. Thus, as a leader, I learned to focus on the small groups first then use these models to generalize to help other groups as well.

3. Every person has a creative side, and it can be expressed in many ways: problem solving, original and innovative thinking, and artistically, to name a few. Describe how you express your creative side.

"Innovation" is just a fancy word for putting together and improving on the same old ideas that we are used to in completely new ways.

As a student researcher for RISE Research Group, I learned how to model fullerene & carbon nanotube neurotransmitters' molecular structures and derivatives in the nervous system using Avogadro Programming to identify the most reactive molecular states for each type of neurotransmitter. Simply put, I performed literary analysis of existing research on how neurotransmitters impact mental disorders to compare to our ongoing research. Here, I realized the importance of having a solid foundation in various studies; what I learned in Psychology courses about brain structures and event schema helped me understand why the psychiatric patients I read about during my research acted in certain ways that could be seen as going against the norms of society, and what I learned in biology and anatomy courses helped to comprehend how certain stimuli would cause specific neurotransmitters to react and turn red or blue on our charts. Furthermore, as I recorded all of this information, I used my foundations in programming and chemistry to learn how to work Avogadro. Ultimately, we were even able to publish our research through the American Chemical Society (ACS).

In working on another research project studying ways to make MRI imaging clearer, I found myself lacking in specific medical knowledge and had to self-study to catch up on how MRI's work to work with existing software to improve signals and reduce noise on MRI scans to more accurately create images of human internal structures. While the computers I worked with were the ones programming out the ultimate solutions, every solution required months of tedious research and meticulous calculations on our parts and extensively comprehensive understandings of how human brains work; thus, despite how convenient research

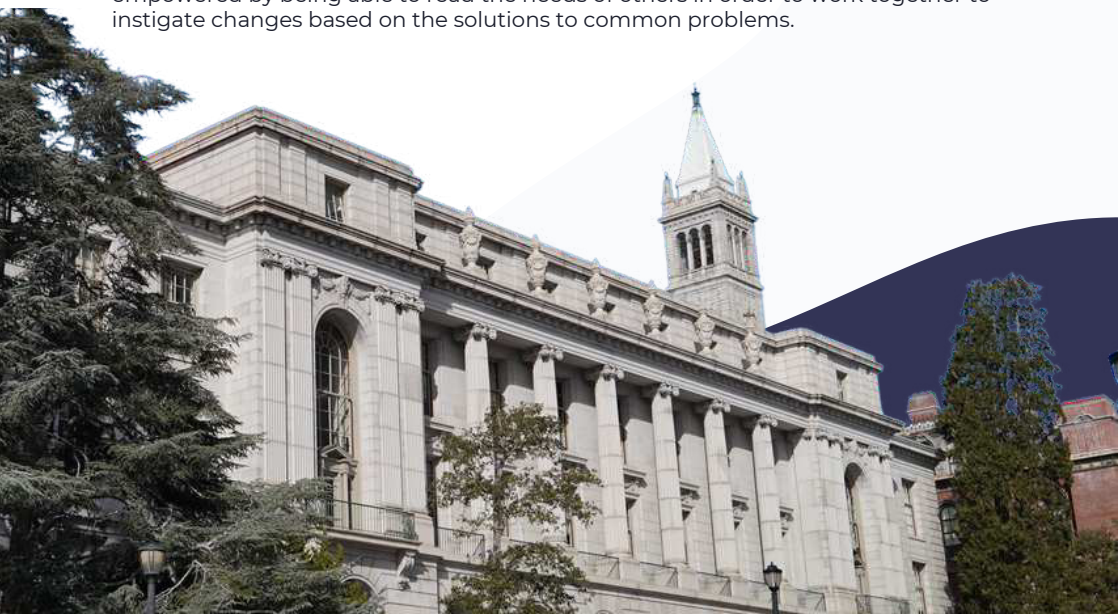
has become due to AI and computer technology, the engine behind how each code runs is the result of a human being's ability to seek out innovative solutions based on the information and resources already available.

4. What have you done to make your school or your community a better place?

As an international student myself, after realizing the difficulties of finding accurate information online about studying abroad programs online, I became more actively involved in online communities for international students. One such Facebook Group called UHoneyTip, geared towards international high school and college students and run by UC Berkeley students and alum, was especially helpful to me as I began preparing to enroll at a community college; as I answered questions within the group, I was given the opportunity to serve as a staff member and am currently the president of the organization.

Under my leadership, UHoneytip became one of the largest online international communities for Korean students with high interaction rates; while other communities focused on providing the most numbers of helpful posts or comments by including paid promotions and posting posts via quantity-over-quality, we worked hard to create small groups through Kakaotalk groups based on general interests such as major, hobbies, age groups, and geographic locations to really focus on what our members needed. In fact, with my active participation, I was able to recognize patterns in what kinds of questions were asked during which months and as a team, we tackled these issues strategically. For example, students tended to ask more about visa-related issues during the months before Spring and Fall semesters began, so we would create news-style infographics about OPT policies and health insurance-related information in January and August. We would also post vacation-related posts before final exam periods, when students would be most actively looking forward to their summer breaks, and post resources for mental health awareness and create social groups during COVID-19 for international students who lived far away from home.

Although I started off with the pure intention of not wanting others to struggle as I had, I now feel less like I am personally helping one person at a time and more empowered by being able to read the needs of others in order to work together to instigate changes based on the solutions to common problems.



For a long time, I struggled with the fact that I didn't feel I was genuinely a Brazilian. Having grown up in Manaus, the biggest city in the Amazon rainforest, the beaches, the samba, and the tropical weather that the media showed were Brazil weren't really what I saw when I looked around. The Amazonian weather was always too sunny or too rainy and, not only did I not look like the beach-tanned Carioca, I also didn't share the physical characteristics of the Amazonian Caboco.

One time during the pandemic, my dad did something that wasn't routine: he tuned into the Brazilian popular music (MPB) radio station. At the time, the song "Onde anda você" by Brazilian poet Vinícius de Moraes was playing. Suddenly, the long-forgotten synesthetic in me somehow resurfaced. The soft and melodic sounds of the trumpet blew me away in shades of a subtle orange harmony while the deep and quiet tones of the string quartet guided me towards a calm rose-like sunset. When the pandemic got a little better, I bought a record player and wandered across the Belle-Époque buildings of downtown Manaus in search of the Brazilian essence distilled in the '70s vinyl discs. The love letters written on the covers, the crackling sound of the imperfect grooves, and the motion of the disc made listening to Brazilian music all the better. It had grown into a ritual, a safe place amidst the lockdown periods.

One day, one artist stood out. With his songs talking about the cultures of the five Brazilian regions, and, most importantly, about the Amazon and the Sertão — the desert-like region where my family had come from — Belchior made me want to see, with my own eyes, the reality behind those lines.

I followed that calling and traveled to visit the Sertão to hear the stories my grandpa had been telling me since I was a little kid. There, the lyrics served as the soundtrack of the story unraveling right in front of my eyes. I saw my family name written in century-old documents. I visited the exact place where my grandparents had met, the weir where my great-grandparents used to bathe their children, and the land where my ancestors proudly worked for their entire lives. I listened to centenarians talking about how my great-grandmother rescued and raised them after they had been abandoned. I got recognized in the street just by looking like my late great-grandfather.

I lived, even if for short, the exact life my grandpa told me he lived when little. Seeing the simplicity and how time runs not quickly, not slowly, but just right in the Sertão made me value every moment a little more. A chat with my grandpa. A coffee with some friends. A beautiful sunset. Every instant could stretch out into eternity if I just laid back, and enjoyed. Life suddenly detached from the everyday madness and became so much more pleasurable.

On that trip, I inadvertently found a piece of me that had been missing for a long time. Seeing the true portrait of the diversity running through my veins, I understood that the difference between the cuisines, the contrast of the appearances, and the variation of accents had grown to be an essential part of me. I had finally found myself.

I can now proudly say every time the needle lowers into an Alceu Valença, a Chico Buarque, or a Milton Nascimento LP, I'm proud to be Brazilian (yeah, with an "s", just like the Portuguese writing). I feel that warmth deep in my heart declaring, in Belchior's lyrics, who I truly am: "I have 18 years of dreams, blood, and South America, by force of this destiny, bossa nova fits me way better than blues". I'm proud to be "only a Latin-American boy", and to truly belong to Brasil, "a tropical country blessed by God, and beautiful by nature".



My 5 foot 3 Grandmother, no more than 55kg, one of the least intimidating people on this planet, is one of the strongest people I know.

As we stood in the kitchen 6 years ago, the layered scent of smoky za'atar hanging in the air, I had thought it was just another afternoon making Lebanese food with my Grandmother. I love cooking with her: she has so much to teach me.

While folding in the corners of the pastry, she recounted the story of her escape from Iraq. Her father, my great-grandfather, had just been imprisoned and died in Abu Ghraib due to him having a British penpal. Iraq was granted independence from Britain in 1932, and the Ba'ath party, 50 years later, were keen to label British people as colonial spies. She spoke of her 14-hour ordeal crossing the desert alone, driving her two young sons to flee the Saddam Hussein regime.

Tossing the tabouleh salad, my Grandmother quivered, describing the hours of fear in the embassy where she wasn't sure if they would be deported back to Iraq, a country that was no longer safe. As loose as it was, her connection to England put the family in considerable danger. I was the same age that my dad was when they fled, 12 years old. I realised that I hadn't faced challenges of that scale in my own life and wondered how I would cope if I did. I felt my father's fear.

That night, my mind roamed. I have had a clear journey in London, finding the perfect school for me, a true friendship group, international influences, and a healthy family construct. In contrast to my education, due to her being a Catholic woman in a male, Muslim society, she was thrown out of university.

I am incredibly fortunate that I have grown up in a world where my life has not been blemished by ridiculous stigmas such as those my Grandmother faced. Today, I go to school without fearing I will have to leave tomorrow, and when I run for my life, it is down the wing of a football pitch, not to flee from my own government. Her story contextualised my life. From this, I have an inherent sense of duty to serve and augment the communities that I belong and contribute to.

Through my Grandmother, I realise we must afford all people the right to be seen for the strength they possess beneath the surface. I worried that I have not always seen the inner strength of others. Had I not gotten the most out of my interactions because I didn't look past the exterior? This stuck with me, and I decided to make changes in my life. I now strive to engage deeply in the profoundness and authenticity with which I speak, interact and listen, truly listen to others. As School Captain, I connect on a more empathetic level with the people I meet, those

interactions are far more insightful and rewarding. As a Chemistry teacher the more I acknowledge my students' inevitable wisdom the more I learn from them. As a Drama director the more I facilitate the actors' contribution, the more unique and exciting the final product becomes. This deep empathy is a hallmark of who I aspire to be.

When we cook together now, I see her differently: Not only as my everloving Grandmother but as a fierce human whose determination is the reason I am here today, free to explore my interests. Living in London, an incredibly multicultural city, where I am exposed to these diverse cuisines and cultures, is a gift I will never be able to repay my Grandmother for. As I look forward to college, a place where everyone is so much more than who they appear to be, I will remind myself of my Grandmother, to find bravery and strength in everyone.



– Kavi

"I always exhaust myself pondering the trajectory of my existence had my parents not lost their lives during Partition", my Nanu (grandfather in our native Punjabi) stated while sipping chai. I interrupted his thoughtful gaze with a seemingly-obvious question, "well, do you feel things would've turned out better had they lived?" He responded with a confident "no." My eyes widened with perplexion, as Nanu's deliberate expression was reborn as a smile. He recounted selling bread on the streets to make ends meet, with just enough to spare for the wilted dictionary with which he taught himself English. His eyes gleaming with pride, he described how hours of lucubration tucked under decrepit Chandigarh lampposts propelled him to Punjab's highest division of criminal law. He concluded his tale with an assured claim, "the magnitude of my adversities fueled my drive towards success".

Although inspired by his resilience, I was suddenly unnerved, as a familiar void of self-disappointment deepened within me. Against all odds, Nanu outplayed the brutal hand life had dealt him. He chose to smile despite having every reason to frown. So why, in such a life of comfort and privilege, was I ceaselessly gasping for air? I only desired to exist in the future, as the present meant facing the adversity of unceasing anxiety.

My journey with anxiety began from an early age, however, it began its crescendo in 8th grade. An ever-so-slight decline in academic performance coupled with typical middle-school social turmoil was enough to derail my system. Through its malevolent tricks, anxiety convinced me that I was nothing but worthless. I would come home from school and immerse myself in study, cursing myself maliciously as textbooks became puddles of tears. I can't even imagine how helpless my mother felt, as she watched her beloved son succumb to his greatest foe - himself.

I couldn't fathom how success could possibly emerge from such sheer brokenness: I was certain even Nanu couldn't explain it.

However, something told me that I needed to keep going. A subconscious force I didn't quite understand, until one particular summer evening. Guitar in hand, I sat on my basement stairs, embellishing the hum of a melancholy tune with strumming when a sudden urge confronted me. *I need a release. I need to write. I need the listening ears of paper and pen to comfort me while I let it all out.* So I wrote. I wrote down my truth, and as the words glinted across the paper I could suddenly feel them floating off my tongue. Consoled in the arms of that same melancholy tune, they told me that pain was my catalyst to happiness. All the suffering, self-isolation, and sleepless nights served as a message: a learning opportunity. Anxiety is simply the language of my body and mind, and it deserved my listening ear rather than relentless suppression. Inevitably, the emotions and

fears persisted, yet they began to appear harmless the more I listened to what they tried to tell me.

Songwriting taught me to understand the process; those who truly desire to make positive change must realize its significance within the journey, instead of the end goal. I find joy in the brightening of smiles at every performance, continuously showing myself that my greatest successes come from spreading light to the lives of others in any way I can.

I vividly remember the twisting in my gut as I climbed up onto the stage. Open Mic Fridays at Cosmo Music was a weekly tradition, but I shuddered at the thought of singing something I wrote. What if nobody understood or cared? The intrusive thoughts began to spiral, but as I pictured Nanu's smile, the words uplifted my spirits as I sang "when I'm alone, pain makes me feel at home...". At that very moment, I felt his presence in my heart, and thanked him silently for his continued guidance and blessing.



— *Maddie*

"What's your pain like today?"

Asked our librarian, Ms. Courtney. She looked strong in front of the books lining the wall behind her, her stature enhanced by stories of tragedy, resilience, and love. She handed me a chocolate protein shake laced with sodium and vitamins, knowing that the chocolate was the only way I could choke down the required medication to ease my symptoms of Postural Orthostatic Tachycardia Syndrome. I braced myself against the back of the wheelchair, and shrugged in response to her question, not wanting to give the full answer. Nevertheless, Ms. Courtney's smile radiated her compassion and eased some of my pain.

Her compassion also helped me see that (even in the midst of hardship) there is beauty. For instance, I remember sitting with my friend on a curb at a festival listening to the joyous laughter of children and watching their faces light up as they climbed a bouncy castle. A woman then came and sat in front of us, using sign language to communicate with her son as he raced towards the castle. The fluidity in which her fingers articulated each sign amazed me. I knew some basic signs so I approached her, and she explained (through sign language) that she was deaf and could only interact with the world around her with signs and lip-reading. As we sat together, I realized that she could not hear the music or her son's laughter. Nevertheless, her eyes were beautifully framed by smile lines. From her, I learned that language in all forms has the capacity to bring beauty to an otherwise broken world.

And I have seen beauty in the cruelest of places.

I witnessed my uncle survive a 99% chance of death from necrotizing fasciitis in his neck, even after the surgeons had given up on him. Although he was in constant pain from his medication, he found humor in an otherwise humorless situation. Some days, I can still hear him call me "Sunny" with a slurred smile and a guttural laugh created by the one vocal cord he had left. I cannot help but smile each time I get into a car as the memory of us driving fast, singing at the top of our lungs lingers with me still. After he recovered, he refused rehab and drowned himself in alcohol until his organs shut down, while the dog we had adopted together lay at his feet. Now, every sunny day, I choose to remember his strength and his resilience but also I remain aware everyone has their own demons and pain.

The next chapter of my life hangs dauntingly and daringly before me. Our world is unstable—politically, economically, and environmentally. Clear communication is the greatest weapon that we possess against the darkest evils prevalent in today's world. And for this reason, I want to continue to learn and educate myself.

For me, International Affairs seems to be the best path for me to help drive out some of these evils. In any situation, I've learned that change starts with listening. To be a better listener, our first step is learning the language of those we wish to help, be it a foreign language or local vernacular. Therefore I see myself expanding my knowledge of various languages in order to better support others.

In the end, I want to be in a place where I can enact real change in the United Nations and create a more beautiful world for those plagued by evil.

"How is your pain today?"

I am still in pain. But it's not the gut-wrenching physical pain that the librarian was referring to. Instead, I am pained like the hundreds of heroes behind Ms. Courtney, each fighting in their own story. There are thousands of stories in this small library—and even more across the globe—so many of them tell a tale of beauty and compassion and their triumph over pain.



My parents, like many others, sheltered me from the world as if something bad was going to happen otherwise. I believed that Singaporeans were all treated fairly and that others were taken care of. That was until June 2018, when one of my lecturers invited me to volunteer with her to deliver food to homebound elderly in the community. I would usually peer into the homes of the elderly, calling out to them. Most times, my heart sank. The elderly were usually skinny and only had just enough meat to cover their bones. This is not how we should be treating the people who built our country. I thought it would get easier each time I volunteered. It did not.

Everytime they thanked me, I heard my heart crack. We should be taking better care of the elderly in our community. All these issues were present while I was growing up, but I did not notice it at all. After a month, I realised things in Singapore were not as rosy as I thought and I was angry. How could my parents hide these issues from me? I had a rude awakening and was propelled into a whole new Singapore, exposed to the harsh realities of the world.

In March of 2020, the Ministry of Health enlisted the help of the Singapore Armed Forces for contact tracing purposes, and I was called to duty. Most of our calls were to migrant workers staying in dormitories. I, along with the Nation, quickly learned that due to their deplorable living conditions, these people were more susceptible to the virus. They had been living this way just to earn a meagre amount of money to support their families in a distant country. This was a human rights issue that I could not turn a blind eye to too.

I started small, by donating a sum of money to causes that mattered to me: food insecurity and migrant worker rights. Was I doing enough? I also started posting links to donate on my social media and asking my friends to donate some money to the beneficiaries. The people around me started to become more aware of these issues and were posting articles to raise awareness of some of the issues I was trying to get people to talk about. That was when I began to see the impact I had as an individual.

At first, it was hard, having to constantly think about other people. I was used to being selfish, only thinking about myself. But because of the experiences I got from volunteering, it got easier and it became a normal thing to do so. What was not normal was allowing these people to suffer, while someone like me, who has the privilege of living comfortably, not do anything about it. This year was a tough year for everyone. Dealing with news about deaths and crises is never easy. However, through this experience, I learned that people need to use their privilege and their voice to effect change. Just because something does not impact me does not mean that I can't be a vessel for change.

I still have this bugging feeling inside me that I am not doing enough. Therefore, I want to explore how I can use my craft to affect change and bring about positive experiences for those less fortunate than me. I believe that films are one of the ways we can spread messages. I want to make use of my experiences and stories to create films that inspire others to act as well. I recognize that the world has endless issues and inequalities and I won't be able to end it. But I can at least have an impact in my own community. I want to bring about change in the next community I will be inhabiting, be it in University or the City I live in next.





Racing to the couch after swim practice, I hear a diverse array of voices and languages. "Marhaba!" says mom, "Ça se passe bien papa?" asks dad, my friend Raymond texts me in English "What were your thematic-stakes in your analysis?" As an international student, my quadrilingual upbringing – English, French, Arabic, and Darija – has opened many doors. Having been all over Africa, I've had the chance to learn about many things, from the trading system of the Malian Soninke to Sudanese desert rituals to Yoruba traditional beats. However, studying abroad has also come at a cost. Speaking different languages in different settings has led me to have, or at least to perceive I have, different identities. Over the years, I've struggled to unify my personalities, to remain my whole self in any environment.

When I'm at school abroad in Zambia speaking English, I'm seen as nerdy and studious, whereas in Morocco, I'm seen as social though lacking intellect, at least I thought so. The different settings I lived in had different "vibes". Intellectual conversations were fostered amongst my school friends in Zambia, whereas in Morocco, my mates' minds were usually on leisure and entertainment. In Zambia, the rigor of my courses, my daily swim-practices, and my extracurricular-endeavors occupy most of my time. My peers only see me in the classroom and – because I don't have time to attend social events, such as bonfires and parties – I'm labeled a nerd. Once, when I asked my friend if I could join the boys on a safari, he replied, "Sure, just don't bring any textbooks with you." Meanwhile, summers in Morocco, I spend time at the beach or playing soccer with friends; speaking mostly Arabic and French. In Morocco, I'm not a nerd. Rather, I'm outgoing and vibrant. But my intellectual side has no room to thrive. My friends would rather play a second game of soccer than hear about the latest economics book I'm reading.

Whether in Zambia or Morocco, I worried whether the language I spoke impacted the way people saw me; and that maybe, switching between them, I was taking on a different guise. I look back at some of these moments and realize the sense of callowness I possessed. Even if the people I'm with aren't into the same heady subjects, I shouldn't have been afraid to express myself fully.

Things all changed 2 summers ago, when I realized it was me who created these obstacles. My friends and I ran into some photographers shooting a documentary for the Women's soccer African Cup. They asked if one of us would volunteer to talk about the exciting atmosphere of this competition, in English however. I remained uncommitted. Yet, my friends, who actually knew my intellectual English-side, pushed me to volunteer. I got a thumbs up from the reporter, and my friends joyfully commended me afterwards.

When I returned to school in Zambia, many classmates who called me a nerd

introduced me to some new French and Egyptian kids as someone who could speak their languages. My English-speaking friends asked me to teach them some French slang. As my vibrant Moroccan personality began to awaken at school, I felt like I was breaking character. But nonetheless, I taught them slang words like “ça-roule”, which resonated with them that, till present, they're slipping them into conversations. I realized then, that my English-speaking friends never saw me as just a nerd.

All along, my friends had been seeing both sides of me – the intellectual and the social. I've realized that academic and social lives don't need to be dichotomous. I can incorporate my comedic side during school much like I can always showcase my knowledge when I'm talking to my Moroccan friends. Learning how to express my whole personality, everywhere I live and in all the languages I speak, was perhaps one of the hardest parts of growing up.



— *Raghuram*

I never let a moment become a memory. And there were plenty of moments. Beautiful sites from the Grand Canyon to Mauna Loa and the bustling cities of Singapore, Dubai, and my own birthplace, Bangalore. Countless flights, road trips, memorable moments, and common among them all: no records to look back too. I always hated taking pictures.

Of course, travel came to a halt. During the quarantine, out of the collective boredom we all faced, I drudged up my family's old belongings. In this dusty mess was an old, plastic bound book with my baby pictures from when I lived in India. These innocent pictures opened a whole new world for me, one I couldn't let go. I showed the album to my parents and was surprised to see them light up as they told stories regarding those moments. Several pictures stood above the rest, ones from a day at the park. They depicted blurry images of a beautiful day in the crowded life of Bangalore. Inside them were a newly wed couple and their newborn baby, me.

My parent's recollection of this memory involved so much curiosity as new adults exploring the world while learning how to raise a child. And I loved their stories. They ranged from terrifying moments of almost losing me, hilarious in retrospect, or detailed aspects about their daily routine, which had changed so much as we moved and grew as a family. In their anecdotes, I saw change and growth that I never appreciated. More than anything, I just enjoyed listening and learning of all these details I had never known. And as I heard more about our history, I became eager to rediscover my past in my own pictures.

But I never took them. My stubbornness to avoid pictures left me with no stories to tell.

When life went back to a new normal, I vowed to take more photos, record moments to transform into memories. It was a simple promise that let me look back at the wonderful experiences I've had. And wherever I was, there were amazing stories intertwined with reality. My debate cases dove further into why an issue existed to begin with, which dragged me through rabbit holes in history where I found even more stories. Science began to form narratives in my mind. When I completed my science fair research, I saw more than numbers and statistics, I saw connections between our collective conscience as students and how the quarantine affected us. And the people we surveyed became more than collections of data, they each carried their own exceptional journey through isolation. I made sure to tell these stories in my research.

I've learned to connect my life with stories, with my memories flowing between each other like chapters in a book. And now that I can combine these chapters and tell a tale through my pictures, I have more moments to look back to. My thoughts and emotions are immortalized. From victory at the science fair, the happiness plastered on my face when I became the Public Forum champion, the pride I held for my team when we reached our fundraising goal for the Leukemia and Lymphoma Society, to once in a lifetime events like my junior prom and all the laughter of joyous evenings with friends and family, all captured through a lens.

I live my memories through pictures, contextualizing eras of my own life and the world around me, and I will take those connections with me into the future. I see stories everywhere, many mirroring my own or others I have already studied and witnessed. Yet some are still unique, proving there is so much to learn, plenty of room to grow, and an unlimited number of stories to appreciate. Because every picture is a memory, every old dusty album, a narrative.

And I will always ask, "What's the story here?"



How does artistic expression shape our perspectives? This question floated into my mind as I stared at the famous painting “The Scream” by Edvard Munch, a bold amalgam of fiery reds and oranges and short, wispy brushstrokes.

As far as I can remember, my favorite pastime was doodling characters on the empty spaces of my homework, standing in contrast with my illegible handwriting. The sounds of classmates talking, sharpening pencils, and the screech of sliding desks would trail off to lush forests, bustling with the chirping of insects and the rustling of leaves. My imagination was an escape from my mundane school routine, so I continued to envision my fantasies.

In middle school, I discovered Webtoon, a comic app for digital artists and the Holy Grail for visual storytelling. I was fascinated by the expressiveness and depth of each character and the use of colors and storyboarding to create complex plots. These stories from creators across the world inspired me to learn digital art to create my own stories.

Teaching myself how to draw digitally, however, was much harder than I had thought. There were hundreds of online tutorials by artists with different styles. I struggled through crooked lines and messy coloring until I could draw portraits and cartoons. However, the biggest challenge was developing my own distinctive art style. Until I discovered digital art, I had only ever drawn still images.

Influenced by years of math and science competitions, I had strived to create the “perfect picture”. Unlike these academic activities, with a strict set of facts and formulas to follow, art was a different challenge. It relied on my own perspectives and ideas, which had been stunted by my earlier impression that there was always a definitive answer. I realized that I was the one who had to define what ‘perfect’ meant for my art, instead of chasing after the styles of other artists and trying to imitate them.

To share my ideas, I opened an art account on Instagram, and slowly grew a following of inspirational friends in the art community. Through their encouragement, I began creating art that represented my passions by combining my knowledge in both art and science to educate others about topics I cared about, through characters who reflected my own aspirations and different cultures as well. The first character, Griselda, of Indian descent like me, was based on a female sultan in Delhi who had rose up from slave status but whose trust in others became her own undoing. My first reel featured her and when it went viral, I discovered that my art could positively influence millions. It felt liberating to see people empathize with my characters, and try to learn more about their stories.

Through my experience sharing my art on a global platform, I've come to realize the power of art as a vehicle to challenge one's perspective and share stories with others. I'm still learning to design my characters in a way that resonates with others. On a fundamental level, shifting from realism, a more rigid art style, to digital art, which was more flexible, opened my own mind up to new ideas, cultures, and histories. I also discovered the possibility of intersecting my own experiences in different disciplines to create art that mirrored my authentic self, but could also teach others about the world. The scope of creativity available through my artistic expression influenced my worldview and helped me see the merits of science and math for teaching and learning, and art as a tool for communicating, and I hope to impact millions through this passion of mine in the future.



University of Chicago, New York University, Duke University

– Sarah



As the sun incessantly falls beyond the horizon, so too does my inner world fall into turmoil. The transformation of the blue sky into glossy pinks and oranges signals an impending battle under the darkness of the night. Since I was young, I have been terrified of the dark—of the loneliness, the irrationality, and the uncontrollable fears that would jump out in the silence. If I was the last one awake, no one would hear me if I called.

It was 2018, in Washington, DC, and I was 8000 miles away from home. As the only religious Jew at the Global Young Leaders Conference, my parents had organised for me to stay with a Chabad family in Brooklyn over Shabbat. Needless to say, I was terrified; on the plane, I stared into the deep blue day sky, wishing for its permanence.

After the flight and short taxi ride, I stood nervously on the doorstep of a narrow house. The warm, wide-smiling face of a mother opened the door, and I was greeted with the scent of challah, a white-clothed Shabbat table, and the familiar tune of Hebrew song.

This was a Jewish home just like mine, yet that evening in the shower, I cried so hard. I would never make it through the night. The anxiety bustled into my head, the thoughts waiting at a platform, boarding the train as soon as I closed my eyes. I told myself that I was being irrational, yet still I felt alone in the world, with these feelings and fears that I couldn't control. I desperately wanted to be with my family, my two dogs, and my laughing brother—with safety, certainty, and familiarity. The tears and water droplets were indistinguishable as they ran down my face.

When my hosts called me to dinner, my heart beat in my chest as I faced a sea of strange faces. But soon, the Shabbat songs, the light of the candles, and the smells of chicken soup instilled in me a comfort I had not expected to find so far from home. These simple traditions brought with them a time of quiet reflection, a recentering of self and a refocus on what's important.

As a young girl I was taught about the power of Jewish peoplehood, the power of Jewish continuity. But it was then that I truly felt I was a part of something greater than myself, a larger story that extended across borders. Here I was, singing the same Hebrew songs that I had sung just a week prior at the tip of South Africa in my own home. Traditions pave the way as footprints of a longer history. I stood here, centuries after the destruction of the First and Second Temples, Spanish Inquisition and just decades after the Holocaust. We had made it through all of that; I could make it through another night. It was like looking up at the stars and realizing that you exist for just a moment in the infiniteness of time. Strangely, it

was in this insignificance that I found strength. I was a single letter in a single word in a book of a billion pages.

That night was the same as many others, my mind running, my heart aching. But it was also the night I realised that I was setting a precedent for my narrative.

As I listened to the divorce struggles of a Russian mother, argued with an Israeli millennial about the future of the Jewish diaspora, and stayed up eating Rice Krispie treats with a 34-year-old New York health expert, I realised this was a gifted moment to prove to myself: I could face and overcome my fear of the dark, of uncertainty, of solitude, just as my predecessors had done before.

There were people awake on the other side of the world. Eventually, I fell asleep.



I distinctly remember the many pairs of twitching eyebrows, tapping fingers, and the exaggerated sighs of my classmates while we had a discussion about the use of nuclear energy in Japan. Although not intended to be a debate, whenever someone spoke, they were immediately interrupted by someone who disagreed with them. We failed to separate our feelings from facts, and by the end of class, I was frustrated by our inability to communicate.

When I was 8 years old, the Great East Japan Earthquake caused one of the most devastating nuclear power plant accidents in history in the region of Fukushima. Since then, rather than cooperating to solve the energy problem, people have been engaged in an endless debate about the benefits and dangers of nuclear power.

In my classroom, the reason for the miscommunication was people being set on their beliefs. As a high school student, I have no control over policy making or research, but I am a part of the conversation, so I searched for a way to converse with as many people as possible. I spent days thinking, and then remembered my love for watching movies. I had always wanted to make my own, but I had never found a compelling story to tell. I looked at my camera that was sitting on my shelf and decided that it was time to make a documentary.

Initially, I believed that I could objectively portray the problem from both sides. I eagerly sent out emails and phone calls to scientists, companies, and government officials, and each interview felt almost like a science experiment. I asked everyone the same set of questions, and I was excited to be collecting so much data with sound reasoning.

However, this strategy started to crumble when I first visited the city of Namie in Fukushima. I tried to simply record the radiation levels and get an understanding of the policies that had been implemented there, but once I heard the stories of locals living in the city, it did not feel right to ignore their perspectives just for the sake of an objective portrayal.

I was guided by a man who had lived there all his life until the accident. He told me his memories of banquets under the cherry-blossom trees, dancing under the red lantern lights in summer festivals, and eating the first bowl of rice that he harvested. Through his eyes, behind the silent and empty city, I was able to see a city similar to mine; I was able to connect with Namie.

For a long time, I focused on positioning myself as another expert on this issue. Not being able to find a clear answer on the subject made me uncomfortable. I felt that I had to be an expert to have the authority to make a documentary, but I was an

ordinary citizen. My experience in Namie showed me that although objectivity is what helps you get unbiased information, subjectivity is what brings out the humanity in what you see. I realized the best way to connect with the audience was to show my personal struggle in picking a side.

During my first screening at a film festival, I was nervous because the documentary did not present any answers. To my surprise, many people came up and thanked me after the screening for my honest portrayal of nuclear energy, telling me that watching the film made them reconsider their beliefs. My documentary ends with the words "We have not lost hope even though we have come far from finding a choice. Our investigation has just begun." By showing my own perspective, I was able to sit beside the audience, and together, we could think about the future of our country.



Welcome to y(our) home

The first time I heard “Welcome, make yourself at home” was when I went to live in the SOS Children’s Village, a Brazilian orphanage. Auntie Goreth, a social mother, was waiting in front of the house with other residents. There, I grew up amongst different stories, setbacks, and dreams. The Village’s sense of community made me feel embraced and safe, especially when we sat around the large wooden table for lunch, to do our homework or to share experiences. Auntie Goreth received me willing to know me, and I harbored the illusion that I would always be welcomed.

All of that changed when Auntie Goreth died and I went to live with my first foster family. The first foster home was a “traditional Brazilian family”: husband, wife, two daughters, and a dog. They said: “Welcome to our home!”, but this “welcome” wasn’t as warm and sincere as the one in the Village. Later, I understood that I wasn’t really part of that family—I would have to either adapt or leave.

I strove to adapt, faking a smile and trying to fit my opinions into their expectations—from choosing a TV show to deciding the dog’s name—even so, at the end of the day, my opinion didn’t matter at all. As someone who can’t keep my mouth shut for more than ten minutes, I felt like a part of me was dying by being constantly silenced. I was losing my essence, my identity—I had to leave.

In my second foster family I heard: “Welcome to our home!”; this family was a little more receptive and gave me time to adapt. However, my sexuality became a problem. One day, my aunt used my younger cousin to offend me, saying he would be a “man,” implying that I wouldn’t. I was shamed for being gay. Eventually, they threw me out.

I began to live by myself in an apartment shared with workmates. For the first time, I didn’t have anyone to say “Welcome” to me: I was welcomed by life. This time I didn’t have to adapt to someone else’s rules—I could create my own. But I still felt watched, surrounded and forced to follow old rules.

Real freedom only came once I moved again. For the first time, I was leaving my country and doing something because I wanted to—moving was finally a choice. I was welcomed by the unknown. I felt unsteady and shaky in the midst of that new world.

At Watson Institute, I felt as welcomed as in the Village. There, people had that same willingness as Auntie Goreth—they wanted to know me for who I was. Different from the foster system—in which people wanted me to fit into their expectations—at Watson, I was constantly invited to share my perspectives. In the

first week, all scholars had to go to the middle of a circle and tell their story. I was nervous to talk in front of people I barely knew in a language that is not my mother tongue. When my time came, I questioned if they would listen to me. But, at the end, I realized I was in a safe place—being gay and speaking my mind was not deemed as a problem anymore. I was finally allowed to voice my feelings.

The meaning of “welcome” morphed every time I moved to each of the different places I lived in, and so did certain parts of myself—I learned not to create nor try to meet expectations. By doing so, I finally felt welcomed. Not because of anyone, but because I know I can shape my future and make it a welcoming place to fit my perspectives, my desires, and embrace the changes to come. I don't need to hide who I am in fear anymore. Just as Auntie Goreth wholeheartedly welcomed me once, I welcome myself.



Harvard University

— Zuzanna

5:43 AM:

I scurry down a gloomy alley, my heart pounding louder than the clatter of my shabby suitcase on the cobblestones. I pray that the zipper lasts this time. Glancing at my phone, I instantly pick up the pace.

I can't be late.

Panting, I charge into the familiar vastness of Katowice Main Station. The thrill of the bustling place runs down my spine. I've never been much of an athlete, but the sprint to catch the Saturday morning train is my specialty. Having traversed this exact route countless times, my feet find the path to the right platform long before my mind does.

11 stops, 216 kilometers, and 2 hours 43 minutes of travel every month separate my two realities.

On one end, Katowice: the heart of Poland's largest industrial area, whose residents — single-income families living off coal mining — reasonably contest my fiery belief in *renewable energy NOW*; on the other, my tiny hometown of Przygodzice. The departure point couldn't be more distinct from the destination. Yet, through my frantic attempts to keep the only child's solemn oath that after moving out I'd balance academic and family time, I strive to merge the two worlds. Courtesy of my beloved Polish State Railways, they intersect at the reality in between.

The hastiness of my steps entering the stuffy train compartment perfectly resembles the hectic life schedule I self-dictated in this Silesian metropolis. The lengthy entries in my journal hint at a possible cause: a burning need to explore the city's endless opportunities.

In Katowice, the local American Corner library equips me with the classics of British literature I vigorously interpret in my Extended Essay (and the same three series of young adult dystopian novels I reread out of pure nostalgia). I religiously absorb both in the cozy premises of Black Woolf Cafe, the greatest supplier of mint tea and the safest escape point for when my microscopic apartment's dangerous desk-to-bed proximity lures me with a nap. Clearly, moving into the city at 18 provided me with a life that the 15-year-old version of myself, hopelessly stuck in rural Przygodzice, could only dream of.

6:14 AM:

When the conductor's whistle announces our departure, I settle myself in the reserved seat and let my mind wander. The rhythmic clatter of the train on the tracks brings me closer to the place that I had once been so eager to leave behind.

And yet now, as we approach, I don't feel the same frustration. By being intentional in my ambitions, I'm learning to combine the warm embrace of my hometown with the exhilaration of the city, the *"life is today"* with the *"what about the future?"* Every choice has an opportunity cost — I know that now — but I'm determined to make it work.

I can't wait to report back to my grandma on the riveting explorations of humanitarian law for my History Internal Assessment and all the speakers we will host at our TEDx conference (even though I know she'll probably just smile and nod). Tomorrow's my grandpa's "name day," a Polish tradition that calls for a big family celebration. I wouldn't admit it to anyone, but I'm a little scared of the day that Julia — my 12-year-old cousin — becomes a teenager and stops looking up to me unconditionally. For now, I sigh with relief as she texts me through her mom's phone, confirming our Harry Potter movie marathon after the party.

8:57 AM:

Stepping off the train, I take a deep breath of the relatively coal-free air and let the Saturday morning sunshine sink into my skin. My dad's already waiting for me at the station — we cover the last eight kilometers together. We don't say much, but the way he instantly reaches for my shabby suitcase tells me everything. My heart beams with calm gratitude. We go home.

Crimson Students' Unique Position

Our Essay Support

When it comes to securing your spot at a prestigious US university, your application essays are not just pieces of writing; they are the key to helping you stand out from the sea of qualified applicants.

Our essay reviewers are the same experts who have helped Crimson students gain admission to the Ivy League and other top schools at a rate that is 4.5x higher than the general applicant. They know what works and how to help you craft essays that truly shine.

Application Mentor

We provide every student with a specialist essay mentor — someone who has graduated from a top university and knows precisely what admissions officers look for.



Personal Narrative

Our methodology helps you develop a complete story that weaves your application together, giving you the edge you need to leave a lasting impression on the admissions committee.

Thorough Revisions

We offer comprehensive revisions with no limits on the number of edits. Our goal is to help you refine your essays until they reflect your true potential and passions.



[>> Learn more about our essay review services! <<](#)

Our Former Admissions Officer Review Service

At Crimson, we also provide a Former Admissions Officer (FAO) review service, where your university application will be reviewed by FAOs who have worked at the Ivy League and other top schools, including Stanford, Duke, UChicago, Caltech, UCLA, UC Berkeley, and more. These experts will evaluate your application as if they were sitting in the admissions office.

[Schedule your FAO review here](#)





*Reimagine what's
possible with*

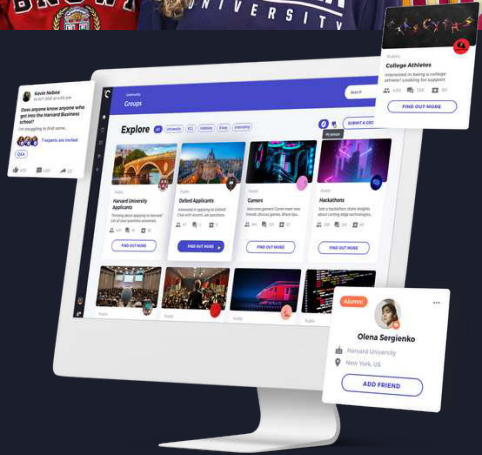
Crimson Education



Who We Are

Crimson Education is an education consulting company that helps students around the world get into their best-fit universities by creating personalized teams comprised of the top tutors, mentors, and admissions experts.

Our one-on-one sessions ensure that Crimson students get the support they need to stand out in today's highly competitive college admissions race.



Our Services

Crimson's bespoke services help you to achieve your educational aims.



**Admissions
Consulting**



**Career and
Mentoring**



**Standardized
Test Tutoring**



**Extracurricular
and Leadership**



**Merit & Need
Based Scholarships**



**Sports
Recruitment**

Our Results

699+

*Offers to the
Ivy league*

233+

*Offers to Oxford
and Cambridge*

4,500+

*Offers to US
Top 50 universities*

1143+

*Offers to the Ivy
League + US Top 10*

Why Crimson?



Our Network

2400+

2,400 expert tutors, mentors, and strategists located around the world



The Crimson Team includes alumni from top 25 US & UK universities in over 20 offices around the world



Our elite board of advisors and sponsors include prestigious influencers at the top of their chosen industry

Our Methodology

One-On-One Mentoring

We provide our students with personalized one-on-one programs, with the best tutors and mentors from around the world. Our advice is tailored for each individual student!

Roadmaps

Each student will receive a fully-personalized program with a roadmap that outlines every detail of the college admission process.

Resources

We believe in giving students and parents around the world access to vital information. We have the largest YouTube channel of any educational company that depicts college life and answers all of your big questions!

Our Technology

Crimson App

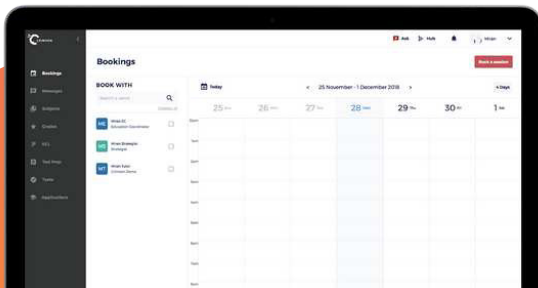
Each Crimson student is onboarded to our mobile & web app, where students can book sessions and view their tailored timetable of customized tasks.

Video Based

Crimson students are able to connect anywhere in the world with their team through our video-based mentoring.

Personality Test

We utilize psychometrics to pair each student with a team that is optimized to his/her interests and learning style! Our test was developed from one of the most well-known data scientists in the world, Galen Buckwalter.



crimsoneducation.org



info@crimsoneducation.org



[Crimsoneducation.org](https://www.facebook.com/Crimsoneducation)



[Crimsoneducation](https://www.instagram.com/Crimsoneducation)



Write Your Way to a Top US University

With the right strategy and the right team, you **CAN** get into a top university. Speak to an Advisor, and develop your roadmap today!

LEARN MORE

CRIMSONEDUCATION.ORG